

PIRATES IN PERIL

It is after midnight, and the *Whydah* is caught in the throes of a raging tempest. Captain Bellamy and his crew work at a frenzied pace to fight the storm, but it is fierce, and the ship is heavily laden. In a terrible moment, the *Whydah* hits a sandbank below the water and begins to topple over. These are the *Whydah's* last minutes, and all but two men will go down with their ship.

The crew struggle to hold on as they pull in the ship's sails.

Life on board

All crew members were treated equally, but fresh food was hard to come by. Pirates would eat whatever they could catch or take from passing ships—and the *Whydah* had a stove and a well-used teapot.



The *Whydah's* teapot probably got its dent before the shipwreck.

Loaded ship

The *Whydah* was heavily loaded when it sank—full of large iron cannons, which would have helped drag it down. On board a ship, cannons are referred to as “guns.”



More than 50 guns have been salvaged.

Pirate style

Most pirates wore clothes that were comfortable and practical for life at sea. But they also obtained more decorative and luxurious clothes from looted ships. They sometimes wore these items to show off.

Tiny pirate

Not all pirates were adults. Around 9 years old, John King chose to join Bellamy's crew when they attacked the ship he was on. But his pirate career was short—a child's leg bone, silk stocking, and shoe were found beneath a gun at the wreck site.



One of John King's leather shoes



Gold buttons and fine belt buckles discovered at the wreck site

"I am a **free prince**, and I have as much authority to **make war** on the whole world, as he who has a **hundred sail** of ships ..."

—Captain Sam Bellamy of the *Whydah* (1689-1717)

7 Loose guns

The guns have come loose. They roll across the deck, then plunge into the water.

8 Flag down

The mast snaps and falls, carrying the pirate flag down into the sea below.